The great bone rush of 1877 · for 2 to 4 diggers · 10–20 minutes

DIGGERS

Rival excavations, season by season

Diggers is a shedding lane battler. You are rival paleontologists working the same badlands. Between every pair of neighboring camps lies a **dig site**, a lane the two of you fight over, and it belongs to whoever brought up the finest find there last. Beat a rival's find to keep its cards, hold sites, and empty your hand: after one field season per digger, the most **prestige** wins.

Components

- **45 fossil cards:** five species (four dinosaurs and a pterosaur), each numbered 1 to 9. A species' nine cards lay out in three rows of three as one fossil slab.
- **4 field guides** (reference cards)
- **6 dig-site cards,** half the size of a fossil card, each with a plain side and an advanced effect side
- **1 Expedition Leader card** (first player)
- Pencil and paper for the score (not included)

Setup

Diggers	Species	Hand	Seasons	Sites
2	any 4	14	2	3, all between you
3	all 5	12	3	1 between each pair of neighbors
4	all 5	10	4	1 between each pair of neighbors

Return any unused species to the box, lay out the site cards plain side up, shuffle, and deal each digger a hand. The leftover cards stay face down, out of the season.



Circles are camps, bars are dig-site cards. With three or four diggers, you may only use the two sites beside your camp.

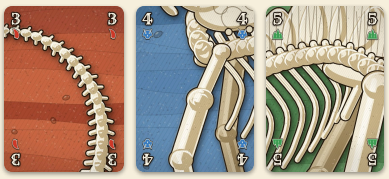
> **Your hand is locked.** Pick up your cards one at a time, each to the right of the last, and **never rearrange them**. Hold them so the numbers face you. The order only changes when cards leave your hand or when you insert a new one.

Give the **Expedition Leader** card to a first digger. Play goes to the left.

Finds

A **find** is one or more cards that sit **next to each other** in your hand and form one of:

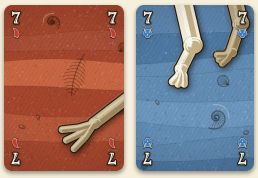
- **A single:** any one card.
- **A run:** consecutive numbers in order, up or down, such as 3-4-5 or 7-6-5.
- **A set:** all the same number, such as 8-8-8.
- **A suited run:** a run whose cards are all one species, such as a Stegosaurus 2-3-4.



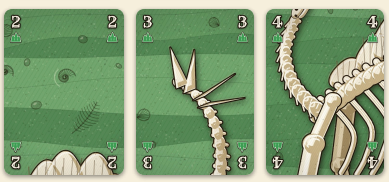
A run 3-4-5, from three different species.

A find may have **up to 4 cards**.

Which find is better: more cards beat fewer. With the same count, a suited run beats a set, and a set beats a run. Still tied, the higher total wins. An exact tie does not beat.



A set of two 7s beats any two-card run that isn't suited, but loses to any three-card find.



A suited Stegosaurus run 2-3-4 beats a set of three 9s.

Your turn

Do **one** of these:

Excavate

Lay a find from your hand at a dig site **beside your camp** (with two diggers, any of the three). If the site is empty, any find will do. If a find is already there, yours or a rival's, yours must **beat** it. Slide your find to your side of the site card: you hold that site.

Capture: if you beat a **rival's** find, keep its cards face down in front of you. Each is worth 1 prestige at the end of the season. If you beat your own find, the old one is discarded.

Poach

Take **one card from either end** of a find at a site beside your camp and insert it **anywhere** in your hand. If that empties the site, nobody holds it.

Then **send a specimen:** give any one card from your hand, even the one you just took, to the digger across that site. They either insert it anywhere in their hand, or turn it away; a turned-away card is discarded for the season.

> Poaching the end of a rival's find weakens it; poaching your own lets you rebuild your hand. Either way, you hand a card across.

If you can do neither, pass.

Example

Ada's hand reads 2 · 5 · 6 · 7 · 9. A rival holds the site between them with a run 3-4. Ada can excavate 5-6-7 there: three cards beat two, and she keeps the 3 and 4. Or she could poach the 4 from that run, insert it between her 2 and 5, and send her 9 across.

Scoring a season

Each	Prestige
card you captured	+1
site you hold	+1
card left in your hand	-1

Ending a season

The moment any digger's hand is **empty**, the season ends. Nobody takes another turn. Everyone scores the season and adds it to their total.

Then clear every site, gather all the cards, including captured ones, shuffle, and deal fresh hands. Pass the Expedition Leader card to the left: that digger goes first.

Winning

Play one season per digger, so everyone leads once. After the last season, the most prestige wins. If tied, the tied digger who holds the **strongest find** at a dig site wins. If that ties too, share the win.

Advanced: site effects

Once you know the game, turn the site cards over. At the start of each season, shuffle all six and deal one, effect side up, to each dig site in play. An effect changes only finds at its own site:

- **Hard Rock:** finds here are 2 or more cards.
- **Shallow Pit:** finds here are 1 or 2 cards.
- **Shared Claim:** a find that ties the one here takes the site.
- **Overturned Beds:** at equal size and kind, the lower total wins.
- **Trackway:** runs beat sets of the same size. Suited runs still beat both.
- **Open Pit:** when you poach here, discard a card instead of sending one.

Tips from the field

- A big find is a wall, and a prize. It's hard to beat, but whoever beats it keeps every card.
- Going out ends the season with nothing in your hand to count against you. Watch how many cards your neighbors have left.
- The specimen you send can be a gift or a weight. A lone 1 between two 7s helps nobody.
- Poaching never shrinks your hand, but it's how you build the find that wins a site.